

ActInf ModelStream 015.0: Andrew Pashea "Active Agents: Agent-Based M

ModelStream | 1:27:08

hello and welcome this is active model
stream

15.0 with Andrew Pasa from ABM to active
inference inference-based action
selection so Andrew thank you for
joining looking forward to this
presentation and overview so go for
it awesome thank you so much Daniel uh
yeah again I'm Andrew a and I uh I am a
full-time data analyst SL scientist
engineer uh many roles to fill when
working in the nonprofit world and uh so
a couple months ago I gave a uh a
workshop like a full uh talk on
constructing active inference agents
using the pmdp library as we'll be using
here today um and uh during that talk I
described

how we might be able to employ active
inference agents uh whenever putting
together agent-based models uh in the
context of computational social science
and so you'll see some links in the
description referring back to that
tutorial that I gave including my GitHub
which has all uh tutorial materials uh
on that page as well as some in browser
Google collab scripts that run python
code and so you can actually follow
along

um a lot of these uh learning resources
including this talk I'm giving are sort
of part of a a personal initiative I've
taken to try and uh create and develop
and then share open- Source learning

resources for applying active inference
um I see so much potential as someone
coming from more of a social sciences
economics oriented background uh you
know for for applying active inference
agents in areas where maybe they haven't
been employed too much before um and as
active inference is beginning to be
increasingly applied to uh social
science research such as uh you know
attempting to study and and
simulate uh something like human
behavior and decision making uh I
thought that that conference was a was a
really ripe opportunity to try and uh
make those kinds of connections for
people and and just kind of get those
kinds of dialogues moving um and
so for me as someone who came to active
inference with that kind of background
but also strong interest in cognition um
I just really wanted to uh kind of do
some from scratch sort of tutorials on
how to construct agents um you know as
someone who's been interning with active
inference Institute for nearly a year
now um and I'll also be giving a talk at
her upcoming posium which itself will be
a kind of extension of that tutorial I
gave a couple months ago as well as the
talk I'll be giving now um yeah I would
just like to uh really make it plain for
people sort of the general mechanics
that go into constructing active
inference agent uh I would also refer
people back to the textbook that was
published a couple of years ago by uh
pulo par and Carl friston um it's freely

accessible you'll find links to it in my
uh slides as well as in the collab
scripts if you follow the GitHub link um
a lot of material that I'm using to
construct these tutorials is actually
coming from that textbook so anyone
involved with the Institute uh reading
group uh where we cover the textbook
will uh kind of feel hopefully a little
at home whenever they follow these
tutorials um so we'll start off now um
we'll be constructing uh the longer span
of the tutorial is one uh make the
connection between active inference and
agent-based modeling agent based
modeling is a very common Paradigm in
computational social science uh that
said and this is not doing it justice
but I'm saying this just to keep it
brief uh in some ways it's very
traditional in the uh kinds of
assumptions that it makes more often
than not about human behavior uh often
times people rely upon a kind of
homoeconomicus or or self-centered uh
utility maximizer kind of a description
of what defines human decisionmaking and
um I think that that loses a lot of the
sort of richness that we find in
cognitive science neuroscience and and
Behavioral Studies uh of how people
might actually make decisions and active
inference supplies us with you know um a
rather you know simple assumption it's a
very complex assumption that being free
energy minimization whenever you break
it down but ultimately that's a core key
assumption that we're making and we

don't have to make a ton of additional assumptions beyond that whenever considering how to simulate uh uh human behavior Beyond how do we construct our model right or how do we construct our agent and so um that's that's sort of the connection that I'm making here between agent based modeling and active inference then after that I describe how what I did with that tutorial was I recreated uh this kind of paradigmatic uh simulation published back in 2007 uh by uh by doctors laser and fredman uh you'll see links to that paper as well at the GitHub site uh through the link and uh what they do is that they set up what I would deem to be a so-called traditional uh social science agent-based model where um agents are basically pre-programmed to do particular things um they don't exhibit autonomous decision making which is sort of the promise of a lot of generative AI today uh and I think that active inference especially emphasizes that sort of autonomy in the sense that these are agents who are you know minimizing their own free energy and then from there you know predicting what should be um the next action that they should take or or set of actions meaning a policy that they should take and uh and so they engage in all these kind of cognitive uh functions or or mechanisms that we we find humans to have related to to planning and um uh the idea of having habits that you build up over time and

how those sort of compete with more deliberate decision making and um you know the kind of uh executive functioning in the prefrontal cortex of the brain and and finding those kinds of connections so um without further ado what we'll do now is simply create one agent and um we'll I'll go through the steps of how to do that and uh this is the agent that features in the uh laser Freedman model Recreation that I do where I use active inference agents uh as opposed to the kind of pre-programmed agents that that they use um so um we'll start with saying again this is pmdp the link is there we import some libraries um It's relatively not too many and some of them are just for like the plots um the main thing is you can pip install pmdp uh there'll be mentions later but there have been many updates to that Library over the past couple of years uh and a little bit more context on PDP as far as I understand it from a couple conversations with the developers is that this package is uh directly inspired by and in certain ways trying to emulate the mechanics of uh the SPM package uh developed by by friston at all uh in mat lab for for constructing active inference agents and environments and processes so um it's it's it's sort of the Exemplar python library for doing active inference as far as I'm aware um and

that said there's so much complexity whenever uh these libraries are constructed and a lot of you know dependencies between different like sublibraries and so on so it it becomes really useful to find more focused sort of snapshots of how to construct say an agent and understanding how those mechanics work without necessarily having to scavenge through the code that said uh there are some examples and example tutorials given at the PDP website it that I've linked there on the screen uh so please uh feel free to peruse those um and so moving on from there uh for anyone familiar with the textbook uh it's very useful to refer to Chapters six and seven uh chapter six refers to uh kind of providing a general recipe for constructing uh a agents and environments and running simulations um and uh then from there chapter 7 kind of expands upon those ideas by specifically creating partially observable markup decisionmaking processes or uh pdps after which pmdp kind of cleverly takes its name and um those are the kind of discrete time discrete State space uh models that we'll be working with that is they they uh play out uh in action perception Loops uh one time step at a time as opposed to it being continuous time so you could say you know at time step one or t equals 1 uh and then at time step two this happens times step three this happens and then discrete State spaces meaning that uh we're not

looking at continuous variables from continuous distributions per se we're looking at uh probability Mass functions and you know just more concrete like you know there's a hidden State uh Factor called color and it has two levels red and blue you know these kind kind of definitive discreet uh uh factors and levels so uh to construct an active inference agent uh probably the this is the general outline all smashed into one slide uh so the first three steps defining States defining observations defining controls action policies um with the nuances for all three of those additional terms so States what are our agents uncertain about uh what kind of you know sets of beliefs do they hold that they end up inferring and updating potentially learning over time uh and then defining observations what do our agents observe from their environment right um it's not enough to like claim that you have an active inference agent and throw it into some you know ethereal space where it has no sensory receptors no sensorium you know you need to be able to Define like what are uh senses so to speak that the agent has available uh the technical phrasing being observation modalities so for example uh an agent might have um you know a visual uh uh observation modality where it can take in discrete levels uh rain or no rain meaning at any given moment it's observing if there's rain or no rain uh through its visual observation modality or visual sensory

receptor being able to clearly Define those kinds of connections almost as if we could view them on a graph which we will do momentarily um and then defining control action policies for all intents and purposes going forward I'm going to be relying upon the word actions um that's because actions are simply in this case discrete actions an agent can take at a given time step um there's nothing more to it than that uh you can walk or you can run or you can sit uh those would be three actions that an agent could do at any given time step right they're not doing multiple of those in the same time step and they're not uh doing them in any kind of deterministic way so to speak um so with controls that's a term that comes up very frequently in the literature and it also relates to other ways of doing say uh reinforcement learning related to engineering problems or otherwise but the the idea of a control is that it's just an action with kind of an additional Nuance to it that uh it relates to the idea of this is an action that can actually change or control something that something being a hidden state or hidden State Factor um so it's you know whenever kind of putting together the matrices involved in constructing PDP agents uh there are times where you'll need let's say a and we'll I'll clarify what some of these words mean for for anyone who's who's still new to to uh modeling here um but uh so with controls

like there might be it might be the case
that you need some kind of subarray like
a b Matrix or submatrix that um you know
doesn't really do anything like it might
be a hidden state for a rat in a teamat
uh who you know they they know that they
can control which location of the
teammates they go to they could go to
the left arm they could go to the right
arm but they don't necessarily think
that they can change the location of the
reward it's always either on the left or
it's on the right and you don't know
until you see it right so it's it's like
the control there would be choosing the
left or right arm and the left or right
arm is the correct option being like the
uh or rather the the left or right arm
in state where the rat infers if it's
gone left or gone right like that is
something you can control moving on with
policies policies are sequences of
actions in this case you could have um
you know in the teamas you have a rat
who can choose to go left and then stay
there it can choose to go right and stay
there it could choose to go to the queue
and then go left uh or otherwise but the
idea is it's just a sequence of actions
uh and so uh agents can have their own
sort of hypotheses so to speak about
individual policies and that's very
interesting to think about whenever
we're considering active inference
agents who you need to engage in kind of
longer term planning Horizons and and
who might be used for you know imagine
uh for people who are into engineering

or or otherwise might be looking at a
like a like scheduling problems or you
know inferring situations where you know
that you're going to need to do a series
of actions in a sequence that maybe need
to have some kind of coherency with one
another such that it's useful to refer
to that specific specific set of actions
as a policy um so Define States Define
observations Define your actions after
that we relate those three components of
a model uh via a series of uh
categorical probability distributions
which are in the a b c d and e uh
matrices um again all these feature in
the the textbook and then uh th those
will comprise the beliefs of the
agent then we Define our environment
which here we're not going to uh for
through the sake of today for the
shorter uh talk we're we're not going to
get too far into defining an environment
uh I will say that common ways of
defining environments especially
whenever you're just beginning the
modeling process is that oftentimes
people will actually construct another
PDP which itself represents the
environment because in that way can take
in its own observations those being the
actions of the agent and then it can
output its own actions those actions
being the observations for the agent
that's forming kind of squaring the
circle on our action perception Loop um
but uh for the sake of today we'll just
be looking at a fully deterministic
environment where I manually have it

take certain inputs send out certain outputs it's still an environment it's just not a very complex one uh and then after that we just Define the active inference Loop run it as a simulation runs the full loop agent receives observations in first States it learns first policies it commits in action then after that uh good modeling practice if you're actually trying to to do something with what you're modeling uh and and trying to model some real phenomena is that you would look at the results of your uh simulation you would look at what makes sense to you what doesn't Maybe maybe there's some parameters that uh don't quite make sense that you've set up for the agent maybe it's missing an observation modality um or or otherwise or uh if you're you know using these simulations in a in a kind of more productive way to to derive insights then the idea is that you could tune things and you could modify the environment as if you're you know um uh uh introducing some kind of intervention and then you could see how things play out differently right in the case of people who are maybe concerned with with policy design or or kind of analyzing uh agent Behavior under uh various kinds of conditions uh the agent we'll be constructing today is uh an agent whose task is to find a good solution to a complex task of problem uh the idea is that uh the Fuller idea is that they're trying to navigate what's called an ink

landscape which is you know you could
you could visualize this as a broad set
of
solutions and each of them has its own
Fitness value so we're looking now at a
fitness landscape at any given point in
time in the Fuller simulation which I'll
cover in maybe future talk is that at
any given time an agent has a solution
currently um it can for the sake of this
talk I'll say it as simply as this the
agent can either at each discrete time
step during the action perception Loop
they can either explore meaning they try
to find a new Solution that's better
than the one they currently have or they
can exploit their neighbor which means
they steal their neighbor answer um this
is for more context this is useful for
understanding like if you wanted to uh
put agents into a network where they
interact with one another which is
precisely what my multi-agent simulation
from the tutorial does again uh review
the GitHub uh all the code is there for
doing so uh the rest of the slides in
this particular slide deck also uh get
into that but we're only focusing on
these um so the the agent can explore or
exploit and a quick note as well that
let's be cautious not to confuse the use
the words explore and exploit here with
how they appear in a lot of the
literature uh on the explor versus
exploitation problem um here we're just
going to say those are the names of the
agent actions they could be replaced
with study or cheat right um but I'm

just I recreated uh the laser Freeman model they use explore exploit it makes sense in a particular way and so we're going to stay with that um after that the agent will infer an intention hidden State uh that is they'll they'll receive observations uh from their environment they they they chose to explore or exploit they receive observations as a response from their environment they'll infer a hidden State and then they'll learn meaning they'll update the the the parameter values of their a matrix or likelihood

Matrix um move to this this is much more representative of the process so we can start at the top the agent explore or exploits

environment takes in those actions and then based on uh based upon whatever rules you set for it to have or you could again you could construct some kind of you know generative model um that you know will kind of do it on its own uh follow you know you could add stochasticity or some kind of you know error term or something so that it's you know it's not entirely

deterministic however you like um but it will generate observations at any time step the agent after committing an action it being sent the environment the environment processing that action the environment will send back two observations to the agent um these upper to Improvement or no improvement showing that oh the agent explored for example and then saw an improvement in its

solution to the problem and then or no improvement you know and then uh the other observation is self or neighbor which is a one to one uh uh mapping that is if you explore it's going to return self if you exploit it's going to return neighbor. The idea is this agent has two observation modalities one of the first one relates to the quality of their solution uh and and outcome of their action uh and and then the second observation modality simply is a kind of self-reflexive

uh observation which is who did I attend to after that the agent will take those observations to infer hidden state it only has one hidden State Factor uh that contains two levels self and neighbor uh there will be again a one to one mapping between self and neighbor if you see the outcome you attended to yourself then you're going to infer that you attended to yourself vice versa for neighbor um and then in addition to that inference learning occurs uh which uh modifies the uh categorical probability distribution describing uh the the probability of those outcomes given State beliefs and the agent from there infer actions or policies you should take and carry them out and we

proceed so this and there will be times that I might Zoom through particular slides um but in this case this is one that's good to reflect on um something that I think a lot of people miss uh or or maybe struggle with uh having been involved with the Institute the reading

group for some time and having my own trials and errors and in learning how these things work uh is that there's a lot of nestedness we're working with a lot of uh

matrices uh anyone who not only works with PDP uh but also math lab and SPM is is very familiar that it's it's crucial to be able to understand how to construct matrices how to construct matrices that represent categorical probability distributions I.E for the agent their beliefs um and uh and so it's it's really important to wrap your head around that and so I just really wanted to spell things out and there's an additional collab script that I'm currently writing that already has now a bunch of markdown cells so that you can not run the code uh but you can see like full descriptions on how these things work um all I'm basically adding more things to to that script that that weren't available uh to me or or I just didn't have time to include uh one of our devices initial tutorial um but now that we've uh defined our hidden States observations and controls um we'll link them together through the a b c d and e matrices and so hidden States uh a clarification on terminology uh agents will have hidden State factors they're they're called hidden State factors they'll have uh you know say and hidden State factors and uh and and so our agent has only one it's the attention hidden State Factor

containing two uh discrete levels uh
self and neighbor you see the same exact
kind of nestedness with OB observations
and observation or sometimes referred to
as outcome modalities so you'll have M
observation modalities our agent has two
of them one of them is for outcomes uh
which uh the discrete levels of which
are Improvement and no improvement as I
showed before um this code actually
includes a third one called
unobserved uh it never comes up in any
of the simulations I run I thought it
would be interesting though to include
it if only because it shows that you
know you can include uh additional
dimensions in your model even if you
don't know if they're going to come into
play at any point the simulation uh it
can potentially change things depending
on how you set those initial values in
in the uh belief
distributions but uh you know for the
time being I just wanted to show that uh
it's possible to do that and finally uh
controls and control factors uh so
actions uh you know again as I earlier
an action is just a discrete thing an
agent can do you could have similarly
with nestedness you could have a whole
control factor of different actions an
agent could take with a total of f
control factors our agent will only have
one and it'll contain two discrete
levels or discrete actions explore and
exploit as far as defining hidden State
factors hidden States observation
modalities observations and then

controls or actions um this is it this
is all the code youi um that's part of
the and I'm following a certain kind of
Gom clature that PDP uh the developers
use in their tutorial website it's a
it's a very clever way of keeping track
of things um none of these string values
like self it's uh Improvement none of
them matter so to speak um they're just
a good point of reference
by uh including them in a list so this
first list attention state names
represents the hidden State Factor uh
for attention and it just it the list
contains two discrete levels self or
neighbor I included one in this
simulation to note you have one neighbor
so neighbor one uh and then from there
you just store uh the number of states
uh for each instate Factor uh this is
appears a little redundant because we
only have one but I'm just you know this
if you were to add like say multiple
hidden State factors this would be more
interesting um and then tracking the
number of hi State factors that you have
um for anyone who unfamiliar with Python
Programming the lane Len uh method
allows you to just see what is the
length of the object that you're
inputting so we only have uh one hidden
State Factor which leads us to uh
one the next small code snippet very
similarly now we Define each observation
modality the outcome observation
modality has three discrete levels
Improvement no improvement as I
mentioned earlier

unobserved the attention observation
modality contains two discrete
observations cell for neighbor one so
recall that in a given time step an
agent is going to receive one of each of
these so at uh you know time step four
the agent could receive Improvement and
name one or could receive no improvement
and self or unobserved in s the point is
that it will receive one of each right
um again we track those using uh the
length or Len uh function and then once
again actions uh we put them we only
have two actions so I just referred to
it as the action uh control factor and
we included our two actions you can
explore or you can exploit neighbor one
and we track that the number of controls
available to the agent um again that
that's it and and if you can determine
you know this kind of design for your
agent early on uh and then begin
programming I mean as as the authors of
the textbook acknowledge uh it's quite
an iterative process whenever it comes
to to computational modeling of just
about anything that includes active
inference agents and and running uh you
know simulations and and so on so um
this is a very crucial First Step
because it'll inform a lot of what you
do next as well as you know what you
might end up changing during that
process of of iteratively you know
changing your your model of your
model so the a matrix is the first step
of linking these things the a matrix
will link together the observation

modalities and hidden State factors uh
that we defined earlier we need one sub
array for each outcome modality so I
want to just draw attention to this
upper right equation um again Matrix
operations are perhaps the the main
hurdle in learning how to construct imdp
um agents or any PDP agents including
matlb um so a useful rule of thumb is
just remembering that whenever you
construct uh a matrix to represent say U
you know the a matrix the likelihood
Matrix uh you know that the probability
of whatever outcome you're looking at
whatever observation modality you're
looking at we'll start with the outcome
one which again uh includes Improvement
no improvement none observed the
probability uh of any of those
observations conditioned
on every single one of your hid State
factors which nicely for us is as simple
as uh the the way it looks to the far
left which probability observation
modality outcome uh conditioned on the
hidden State factor for attention right
so we're really just uh working with
these these two Dimensions um it it
would become threedimensional matrices
if say we had two hidden State factors
this would get expanded um so uh the
typical way of doing this in PDP uh PDP
contains a sublibrary utils uh
containing just different utility
functions and the the sort of framework
for constructing these kinds of uh
beliefs in p M DP is by using what are
called object arrays which are already

available in the numpy library uh it's effectively a numpy array that allows for uh data types aside from float values so it's kind of a more flexible version of a numpy array um and that allows you to do things like say create um an a matrix that's your representative of your overall likelihood Matrix for everything all observation modalities and state factors and then you can construct within it individual subarrays one for each observation modality and that those subarrays can be of different uh dimensionalities from one another and so it's it's just again wrapping your head around kind of the nestedness here um and a lot of these things are better represented in the the code I've written so might touch on that if there's time um uh of course this is code I wrote too with the the collab script which uh contains code that you can run and it has different ways of expressing these different matrices but you can see the point is that we're now that we've defined our hidden States our observations our actions we're going to start linking them and to represent our agent beliefs so uh for this situation I print the outputs

all code that you've seen so far with the gray shading that is uh you know at the beginning we imported libraries and then two slides ago we um we looked at defining H State factors observation modalities actions now this is our a matrix um I'm not getting into the maths

on this a matrix because it's easier to just look at the outcomes um this is how we've construct like all this code that I've shown so far can just be run like in the order that I've shown it thus far you'll see that in the collab script um here the first subarray again which is for the outcome observation modality we'll notice for those who are familiar with probability Theory um probability distribution sum to one uh that that's help what's helpful is that the utils uh subl library has is normalized uh function where you can put any object array into it it'll tell you if it's normalized or not so helpful rule of thumb to ensure that you've done everything right before you proceed further um and so what this does is that it lets us see that if we sum these values um each outcome uh per pin state level uh we can see that it's entirely uniform it's it's totally uncertain it's not useful to the to the agent there's a third probability that they'll see an improvement if they attend to themself third probability if of there being no improvement if they attended themselves there's a third probability of seeing an unobserved outcome if they attended them um it's very common practice if you're attempting to model a more realistic um you know phenomena or or organism or human and you have no idea what they would do uh it's CA practice initialize them with uniform priors here I'm just doing it for the

sake of Simplicity and a in a tutorial
right um and so uh meanwhile with the
next subarray as I said earlier uh
there's one to one mappings between the
uh attention observation modality and
the attention hidden State Factor so it
it's as if the agent has
completely certain beliefs like the
polar obosa
uh about um about who it's attending to
right so if it sees that it's attending
to someone um attending to itself then
it will infer its intend attending to
itself and vice versa for
neighbor and that's it uh that's the A
matrix and then we have the B Matrix
which I would say is equally complex and
then Things become immensely simpler
from
the B Matrix again equation top right um
uh we need one subarray uh B Matrix for
each hidden State Factor this is very
simple we only have one hidden State
factor it's the attention hidden State
Factor um and so our agent wants to be
able to track um if I'm currently
attending to let's say myself and I
choose to explore what will the hidden
state be at the next time step thus s to
plus one conditioned on
sent the hidden State present uh
combined with π which is representative
of the action or policy undertaken in
the present um this is also going to be
incredibly simple it's really going to
be one to one so at any given point in
time um the agent will
believe that regardless of what state it

is

in uh currently it will transition to self if it chooses explore probability one if it was in if the current state is neighbor it'll transition to self with probability one if it chooses explore and similarly it always believes that it'll transition to the neighbor in state if

um regardless of whatever in state it currently believes it is in so uh a a a comment that that might come up for anyone who is familiar with these things this is not terribly uh different from just a standard Markov decision-making process right it's kind of like well if the agent has all these fully certain beliefs why create a partially observable environment um there there's a certain reason for that and then there's another just more direct reason for that the direct one is that this is how pmdp Works um and then also I the the other reason is I think that partially observable environments are more representative of our reality I think it aligns with the idea that we do often have noisy sensory receptors uh you know whether you have 20/20 Vision or not uh it doesn't mean that you can uh you know see every color that's every uh ever existed and it doesn't mean that you know you can see perfectly anything uh and so the idea of just this noise being there and the idea that you have to infer you have to rely upon observations to infer beliefs and having those kinds of Loops you know it all um

kind of makes sense and then there's another aspect uh that will come up soon whenever we discuss learning for the C Matrix which is uh representative of preferences or priors over observations this is basically denoting uh it's as if we're saying uh what are the outcomes the agent actually wants to see like or observe what are the what are the observations it wants to to to see happen uh as oppos to those that it doesn't right and so this is immensely uh easier to construct uh versus the the a matrix or the B Matrix um in that we're really just effectively creating these vectors um so we need one subarray for each outcome modality or observation modality for the first one uh the outcome modality the way that we've defined this is take a list uh each one of these values is indexed to the observation in the outcome uh observation modality as we saw before so recall in order the first one is Improvement the second one is no improvement and the third one is unobserved these line up exactly uh in the same way and uh reiterating Again The Matrix operations uh and and being able to grasp like how indexing goes here uh as long as everything lines up uh it it'll be solvable right the the the free energy calculation will be able to be carried out as long as everything kind of is in its place right so so it's uh

do your best to never confuse uh you know which position each of these represents so the reason why these values don't sum to one uh common practice uh that I've seen a lot in previous mat lab scripts and so on is U uh people will actually use these like whole integers and even negative values because it's just kind of a more human friendly human interpretable way of of experimenting with an agent's preferences um whenever you run this through the soft Max function uh which which is also applied here this basically strongly amplifies um the the final probability distribution that that arises and also turns it into a probability distribution that does SU to one um and then uh before we move on to see what that looks like for the second observation modality uh the attention observation modality we're going to make that entirely uniform as well what each of these really is saying is that the agent strongly prefers to see improvements in its solution it dis prefers seeing uh no improvement in its current solution and it is indifferent to um to the unobserved observation it's not exactly how the math would play out because of the softmax function but it's effectively something like that and in any case in this simulation we won't be uh seeing the the unobserved um observation come up at all anyway and then for the second one uh fully uniform preferences uh that simply

means that the agent has no particular preference towards u whether it's attending to itself or to its neighbor right so you could experiment with this you could see like what what happens whenever an agent actually prefers to do uh its due diligence and and primarily just explore and come up with its own answers to the to the solution or what if you come up with an agent who more so prefers to steal their or exploit their neighbors's answer in any case here we'll just we'll stay totally u agnostic to uh that and just say that the agent has uniform preferences so those end up looking like this u whenever we print them out uh again these are normalized uh we see how the softmax uh function strongly Amplified uh where where where this uh the the preference for improvement was a five it's now become a 0.998 continuing uh probability and so so this relates back to the idea that agents are self-evidencing they will uh based on how particularly expected free energy is computed uh where it includes C uh within the pragmatic value term u this is what will guide the agent towards uh you know towards observations that it prefers as opposed to others uh making this move Beyond just uh you know an agent who's hyperreactive to what's going on in the present instead of an agent who might uh prefer to uh see certain things and therefore act in a way to kind of realize what it prefers again here uh preference really just

meaning it being what you expect um and then again uniform distribution for um for the second uh modality it has no particular preference towards observing itself or uh observing its neighbor as who it's attending

to then D fortunately for us we only have one hidden State Factor so this is the shortest description it's similarly to how C was a uh you results in a probability distribution that uh describes the prior over observations the D Matrix does the same thing but for States and we only have one hidden state so we just have one sub array for uh the attention hidden State factor and um you know so again we just uh and I didn't mention this earlier the the np. ons is just generating um a vector uh equivalent to the number of hidden State levels that you have so a vector of two ones and then you're normalizing it using the utils library right so take two ones normalize them you're going to end up with

0.55 the ematrix are your habits uh you don't actually necessarily have to Define these uh whenever you're you're constructing a pmdp agent uh I find it to be very useful if either one you actually want to uh you know uh run some kind of experiment where you think that the agent will actually have more of a a sort of uh a habit of doing one particular action over the other um it's also useful if say you're trying to set up a different kind of simulation that's more focused on uh policies in which

case you know it might be the case that you know you only want uh the agent to have a strong prior belief for entire particular policy versus another uh and and use that as a way to to define the agent as having beliefs that you know a particular policy won't at all work versus one that will such as um you know uh dry off and then jump in the pool as a kind of an odd thing to do um or or you know could come up with some better example in the fly but I I think the point comes to cross right so in any case this is just basically your priors over your actions that get Incorporated so what did we do uh we we we related States and observations in the A matrix we related States and actions in the B Matrix uh and then C D and E are just the priors on States uh excuse me observations States and actions respectively um also recall uh from the from the textbook and elsewhere that the agent has a separation from its environment uh called the notion of a Markov blanket and so uh for the for the agent UHS like despite certain things occurring during free Min energy minimization to where uh observations and actions do in fact end up influencing one another vicariously uh we have not expressed a probability distribution that actually directly links observations and actions so it's kind of maintaining the blanket States of uh of your active state sensory States and and you'll you'll see that in the textbook uh reading the the

section about marov blankets so it's just maintaining that that kind of Separation then um I will go just a little bit longer than what I expected um so now that we have our a b c d and e um one additional thing that our agent will do is that it will learn uh you know the idea of learning an active inference uh there's plenty of literature on this but it can relate to you know the idea of for the sake of a model what we're doing is that where're we're assigning sort of these hyperparameters or priors to uh to the uh matrices that we just Define themselves right so what our more specifically what our agent will do is it will learn its a matrix the likelihood Matrix that we Define first out of the those five things a BC D and E and uh it it will just update it based on the new observations it receives and the in state that it infers um and it will also answer a question as to okay why did we have set up hidden States and observations and actions in that way why are we doing these like identity mappings between particular things um by learning the a matrix that will allow our agent to learn if it's the case that when it explores it'll be more likely to see an improvement or uh or no improvement right this will allow our agent to by accumulating observations over time in the action perception Loop um it will begin to better update uh its beliefs about which thing it should do

and so even though we you know
previously we defined ϵ as being uniform
over those two actions to where the
agent initially had no particular um you
know bias towards exploring or
exploiting it will actually probably
start to bias the agent towards one of
those directions because it prefers to
see improvements and that can only occur
through learning uh without learning and
modifying internal uh parameters of your
model you're effectively uh you know
sort of like a
pre-programmed uh uh Theros thermostat
or something right you're
nonadaptive you just act in the same way
as you always do and so an agent who
doesn't learn as the one if we Define an
agent like we just did but it never
learns then what it will do is more than
likely just with a 50/50 chance choose to
explore or exploit just keep going uh
from there so um the way that we update
the A matrix for the PDP agent here um
is that we is quite simple and this is
it you don't even need all this code you
only need the code in the upper right
but it's basically this uh small P
capital A is the prior that we're
creating uh what we're doing is that
we're using that util sub Library this
de lay like function which basically you
construct your A send it through the
de lay like function it'll convert it
into what is a kind of Exemplar
conjugate distribution of a categorical
probability distribution uh that being a
de lay distribution it it affect

whenever you print it out you see that we set scale to one it looks exactly like our a matrix um what that scale argument does is that it scales the values that's the special thing about the Matrix dlay distribution is that it's something like an accumulation of pseudo counts that will then weigh uh you know particular um comp parts of the the competition of free energy minimization uh for example the agent might start to see more instances of improvement uh and so it might start to upweight uh the the likelihood of uh Improvement uh given the association that it saw it with you know and so the these don't actually have to sum to one they're just kind of like waiting our any Matrix and they're very relatable to the notion of uh Precision right like if a if an agent hardly has any previous experience uh with anything and it's and it's it's it's U uh prior over a is highly scaled down meaning it it has very few pseudo counts of any prior experience uh it's the agent is going to be less certain in its ability to make connections between uh exactly what the a matrix tries to model which is the relationship between observations and States so um so these values can themselves you know be set differently and and you can set the Precision differently and then they can impact the the agent uh differently now we have all of that this is it for constructing the agent uh it's basically just an agent class and so you

just feed in the arguments they're actually many many arguments uh that can go into the agent Constructor um it might seem like a lot there actually uh I think literally a couple dozen more uh but that it very much mirrors the construction of the mat lab SPM package for anyone familiar with that um there's a whole script you know that that will run through and and try and construct your your markup decision- making process your agent and it'll check to make sure that all these uh you know boxes are correct like is the a normalized is you know how did you set Gamma or some other thing and so it's you know in spirit this is very similar to that um what's nice is that the the PDP package um it has different inference algorithms um not many but uh as opposed to choosing sort of the standard one uh I've chosen MMP uh which is marginal message passing there's a nice paper on it that uh can be found in the speaker notes of the tutorial slides I make a brief reference to it here part all 2019 and um so marginal message passing basically being a kind of U you know in a certain way it's a kind of compromise between uh uh overcoming intractability and and attaining achieving something like computational efficiency and approximation that you get with variational message passing but at the same time um it it it it it overcomes some of the issues of not um um having certain Precision terms

involved

that uh you know that leads to issues with VAR variational message passing that it it it can be uh it can lead to overconfident posteriors in the computation and meanwhile belief propagation is much more holistic but um more computationally expensive sometimes tractable depending on the situation so MMP is a nice way of striking balance uh trying to find that balance between complexity and and accuracy as we are always trying to do right um so you you'll notice uh that we plugged in everything that we defined so far A B CDE e and then the prior over a shows MMP just a little bit more explanation of what some of these other arguments are um but uh given the time and also simply the fact that I mean um we would have to go into a lot more to look the other options available I would say this suffices um you know if you want to play around with any of these um certainly go for it and especially recommend looking at inference Horizon in the policy length uh arguments um this agent is very simple in the sense that it makes no future planning steps for for constructing policies that go beyond just should I explore now or should I exploit now um it it can make inferences one additional time step into the future though so it does in a certain way allow it to have this kind of forward looking n where it'll not just try to anticipate what will happen next but it'll try to anticipate what

will happen next next so you know the next time step and the one following that um and

uh yeah I also chose stochastic action selection you could choose deterministic instead there's a note on how that works um basically you know if uh if you're posteriors over policies or that uh you know U explore has a value of one you'll choose that with probability .1 right so there's still stochasticity involved um but you're just going to be more likely to choose the option with the highest probability um deterministic means you would automatically go for the the action that has the highest probability assigned in the posterior so those things in mind uh this is the general process uh that will be carried out in um an active inference Loop for our agent it'll infer States uh which you know once we've constructed our agent uh the agent and this is common for other reinforcement learning paradigms as well um you you have an agent and then that agent will have a series of attributes that you can access at any given time um this our agents have an infer States method which can then take in um the observation and then after that uh whenever it comes to learning uh the the PIP install version of imdp has update a b and d matrices uh available um there are uh I I to briefly hearken back to this there have been many updates to the PDP Library over the past couple years it's very exciting but uh I didn't want

to give anything too definitive because I think many things are still in progress but right now they're they're acting developing means doing model fitting uh which are already there uh it's just I can see that they're they're kind of cleaning some things up they've also you know there there's a there will be means of using the Jacks back in to speed up a lot of the processes which is very exciting and also they've implemented a sophisticated inference uh which is another way of doing policy inference uh using a kind kind of optimizing the tree search um but I uh in addition to those updates uh they'll also be updating the abilities such that the agent could learn its preferences or its habits uh or other aspect the aspects these are just the the PIP install versions uh currently available methods then agent will infer its policies and then it will sample its action

um so inate inference again we're using marginal message passing um interesting thing about pmdp is that um the only time that F variational free energy really comes up as far as the code goes is that um f gets uh scored across policies rather than being the more General free energy of the overall system per se but in certain ways from looking at the raw code that carries that out uh it appears that you know there are other aspects involved um but for the sake of the tutorial we'll just say what interesting is that uh free

energy is the same for both actions at any given point in time and I think that in part is due to the fact that the complexity term uh in uh V defining variational free energy for each μ action or policy μ it's dependent on this uh the posteriors Over States versus uh your prior which starts to look like your B Matrix regarding uh State Transitions and the agent has fully uh predictable fully uh you know identity mapping one to one mapping in its B transition matrices and I think that's what actually brings this complexity term uh down to uh virtually zero right uh it's like the the posteriors are basically matching what it it knows what state it'll transition to and if it doesn't ever look learn its B Matrix and never has any opportunity otherwise to see something different from what it already believes then it's as if the agent fully believes like okay you know complexity is gone all it's left with is accuracy and so it's accuracy actually the difference between observations and States that's what's going to lead to the fluctuations in the variational free energy but this is all the code you need a really important part is the way that this `OBS` Ops uh variable or object is defined again it's very important to keep track of your indices μ at any point in time you could you could Define an `OBS` object like this which is a list the first element of `OBS` corresponds to the first observation modality which for

us was outcome and then the the value
itself refers to the index of the
particular observation in question so
what we're saying here is the first
value representing the observation
modality outcome modality u_m that first
value zero is index to Improvement and
you can see that same logic uh plays out
for the second element in the Ops list
um you know this is for the attention
observation modality and zero
representing self as you know what it's
indexed to and so it's as if the agent
just observed that it was attending to
it itself and it saw an
improvement we simply run that through
uh the agent. in first States method uh
and plug into Ops and then the agent
will update uh it'll find Qs meaning
it's it's posteriors over hidden States
and uh those will actually get stored in
the agent as an attribute as well but um
but the the method Returns the object
and so I'm you know we're keeping it
here Qs and then you can look um we we
didn't have to explicitly say anything
about Computing F it's just this INF
first States um uh run then led to uh an
internal computation of f in the agent
that we can now access
print so this starts getting into um let
speed through this a little bit but
because I already touched on various
things but this is another breakdown you
know it's very useful to look at the
different breakdowns of uh variational
free energy and expected free energy and
so on um but I'm GNA move through this

slide and come because we'll get back to policy inference shortly

uh this uh this is to show that Q_s the posteriors over hidden States uh is rather complex whenever you use the marginal message passing um uh algorithm uh but it's also very interesting in that the the way it gets broken down itself being a rather complex three-dimensional matrix it's that the First Dimension refers to policy um if if we if we kind of open it up as it were um and the second one where uh is the time step and the third is the hidden State Factor so what this is saying is that um for the first entry uh which relates to explore and then the time step if you make you know the first entry of that means now and then in state Factor we only have one of them so the first entry is the only entry the attention in state factor that effectively means if you print Q_s uh 0 comma 0 comma 0o uh it'll print out this first value representing this is what the agent believes to be the hidden State given the policy um you know given the Explorer policy and so we can actually extract that out whenever I have these slightly out of line um we can extract that out and then um Thea excuse me um this line here agent. Q_s uh we can we can uh extract it out via Q_s action sampled ID Z all that means is uh we're grabbing the the agent's posterior beliefs given the actual hint state that it chose um that there's a little bit of complexity and

it get it's it's much much clearer in
the Google collab script um that I've
included so I advise having a look at
that um but this is the code that allows
the agent to uh update its a matrix uh
the only reason why uh we need a couple
extra lines of code is because of the
complex structure of the Qs that um
comes out um of a marginal message
passing
agent and
then we'll look
at

um um policy inference you saw that
there are more slides than what I really
need to explain it but um this is the
final step of the action perception Loop
so for policy inference your posterior
beliefs over your policies uh in this
case are um your negative expected free
energy
times gamma which uh have a better slide
to represent
that here we are um gamma which is your
action Precision so just as I mentioned
like um we can we can put these uh hyper
priors or parameters on our a matrix to
learn the a matrix and and and that
scale argument kind of kind of um down
Tunes or uptunes the Precision on the a
matrix similarly here um we can we can
downtune or uptune uh the the Precision
over G uh expected free energy and since
expected free energy is what is directly
involved in realizing one's preferences
I mentioned earlier with C matrix it's
kind of like whenever we look at this
equation is that we're seeing uh a sort

of balancing act between expected free energy related to sort of deliberate decision making to realized goals uh you know these are very contextual you know uh kind of beliefs and and and uh ways of computing free energy and then you have variational free energy which uh you know is sort of like the the free energy of the present um and it doesn't necessarily take into account anything regarding uh preferences uh you know the C Matrix and what you say you want to see uh it's more about just kind of optimizing your model in the moment and then uh habits which we already touched on earlier um and then those uh we take the we actually take the natural log of those so that they kind of fit similarly on the same scale with expect to free energy and variational free energy so it's kind of like you have these three different you know you have your habits built up from the past you have your variational free energy of the present and then you have your expected free energy of the future all sort of contending with one another and then being run through this soft Max function which as we saw earlier uh when we used it for the C Matrix um that converts it into something that sums to one and then axes our um uh categorical probabilities distribution and the number of entries will be equivalent to the number of actions you have available and so that will look like um in the case of G alone uh it'll it'll look like this you'll have your uh free energy for uh the

explore action and your free energy for the exploit action and recall that uh that we want to minimize this quantity so it's actually the the quantity with a smaller number that's uh better so to speak um and then these values will get plugged into the policy inference equation up top in addition to what we already saw earlier the variational free energy values we saw and then the habits which we programmed even earlier than that so we have now all of components for constructing an active inference agent we have all the components needed for doing uh hidden State inference of having our agent receive observations that it uses to receive uh to to infer hidden States and then to infer policies and to to select an action uh that that's what this slide represents is the ability to uh infer policies um you can print out G and have a look at it uh and then with sample action this is just basically has the agent sample from it's posterities over policies and then this act this extra code here is simply because um you know the whenever you have the agent sample in action it returns it within a list uh and so we need to extract that out of there um and then these last two slides were to represent uh two example simulations that I ran um they're I'm sure they look rather busy as many of these other slides have but there's just so much to kind of look at and get into um with this figure attempts to do is that you

can lead it read it from left to right
uh time like over time steps um from the
start of a simulation to the end in this
case it was 30 time steps
long and then you can also read it from
top to bottom uh where the agent
receives an observation it computes
variational free energy um it learns
it's a
matrix it infers policies and the
expected free energy of each action uh
it it uh along with that that g then
gets included along with f and habits to
compute um posterior beliefs about
policies and then uh finally the agent
chooses an action that gets sent in so
it's kind of like from left right we're
looking at each time step where a whole
uh action perception Loop is happening
and then vertically we're looking at an
entire uh action perception Loop or you
could flip that say perception action
Loop given A_g and is getting getting an
observation first
right and so uh in this simulation I'll
just stick with this one uh but uh you
know in in this
simulation
uh the agent
um receives an initial observation uh it
just forced it to say like self and and
Improvement know it seems good um or
excuse me it gets initialized with with
Improvement and neighbor and then for
the first half the simulation we're in
what I'll call the neighbor context
where in that case uh the simulation is
uh you know it's programmed in a loop so

the agent will receive um
it will always receive uh an improvement
if they exploit and they'll always
receive a no improvement if they explore
so you can see this is a very
deterministic uh and very extreme
environment where uh you know choosing
to explore always leads to a bad outcome
for the agent choosing to exploit always
leads to a good outcome for the agent
and so during the first couple steps
call that our agent starts off with um
you know these uniform beliefs uh as far
as its habits go of whether it should
explore or
exploit uh and so that's where these red
and blue lines and this probability uh
subgraph here subplot uh they line up
with one another they're 0.5 so
effectively the agent is just kind of
randomly choosing one of these two
options and it just happens it choose to
explore both times
whenever it chose to explore both times
for the next two time steps it saw that
there were uh no improvement like bad
outcomes um you know given that and uh
the the agents free variational free
energy of the present uh kind of uh kind
of got jerked downward uh in a in a good
way it's meaning that it's informative
to the agent during those time steps to
see that it's accumulating evidence that
it's seeing that it might be learning
something and in the meantime during the
second time step the agent learned its a
matrix right so um that also means that
there was a lot of updating in its

internal model uh that has led to changes in its free energy as well and then over time uh things start to diverge the agent quickly realizes oh if I exploit I receive this green Improvement observation again and again so the agent proceeds to uh exploit and it actually does it all the time as it's doing it it's seeing that there's less and less expected free energy to just exploit um and then similarly in the final policy inference it it actually reaches um you know a 1.0 probability that the agent should exploit to where the agent is effectively doing this deterministically uh practically given that it keeps inferring that and also this yellow line is especially interesting um and and part of why I wanted to do all this in the first place what this yellow line is doing is that this is me extracting out from it um the probability of the agent seeing an improvement uh given that it attended to its neighbor which links up with exploiting so this is teaching the agent that uh it should keep exploiting um it'll see improvements it'll get What It Wants it'll keep going that way right this agent is adapting to an environment where um you know the that's exactly how this world works right and then halfway through the simulation uh everything is reversed so now uh we went from one environmental extreme to another in the first case the agent saw improvements uh from attending

to its neighbor now the agent will only see improvements from attending to itself and it only see no improvements when attending to its neighbor and because there have been so many instances in its past experience of seeing beneficial outcomes when it exploits its neighbor um the agent now actually has to unlearn what it is learned right um and by the end of the simulation still hasn't fully done that um and uh we we can see this reflected in uh the um expected free energy the it starts to rise again for exploit as the agent no longer sees any more improvements even though uh it's continuing to exploit because that's what it expects so this is a toy simulation in that you might not have learning happen after every two times steps that's a very arbitrary thing that I've chosen to do and it's actually a rather rapid learning rate all things considered more often than not whenever setting up a simulation you'll have an agent who might say learn at the end of a trial where you run 10 Trials of Three Time steps each or something along those lines right um it's less common to run trials over 30 time steps however uh in more traditional agent-based modeling uh paradigms because of their Simplicity you often do run uh you know a simulation over many many time steps right and so I want to make sure that this code is set up in a way that you could run this as long as you

you know prefer to without without too much complexity because I wanted to show the value to computational social sciences as to what they might be able to do um with with active inference agents but now that we're uh significantly Beyond uh you know where where I wanted to wrap up um I'll just take one more minute to say um you know there again there is um you can land at the GitHub uh you know website that I made it's very short to the point and all the links here are uh available for the slides that I was just showing there are many more slides I tried to be rather comprehensive uh given uh you know how much material I'm trying to show and then uh the two collab scripts with this second one being a further development of the original code but I'm adding more explanatory mark off uh excuse mark off uh markdown uh cells that uh kind of better describe things uh including giving examples of how uh the A matrix works and the B Matrix works and furthermore again I I repeatedly emphasize like being able to get your Matrix construction and structuration down I actually provided code on here's how you create you know an A matrix and you can manually uh Define the values it's a good idea to learn how to manually Define the values of the A matrix or of the B Matrix um it looks rather tedious than it is but to be able to do them one by one is a great sort of dactyl means of like learning how to

construct these including whenever we get into these more complex like ways of um you know representing probability distributions where you have three or more Dimensions but once you're able to do that you might just at some point realize oh there's a loop I could write that could do this for me um but you don't quite know what that Loop looks like until you kind of get a sense of what value should be there right so um anyway so the it's the point is that there are just some additional uh tools and information that can be used here and then all the code is available for say uh printing out like running the example simulations and then looking at the plots at the end feel afraid to you know modify and adapt those um as as pleases you so um that's all I have for today and I would love in future to give another uh talk Andor pre-record something that goes into a lot of the other material and probably gives a more kind of cursory overview of the rest especially for people who would be interested in um multi-agent simulations and um and especially kind of using leveraging packages like Network X which will allow you to kind of connect agents and graphs and Define like sort of like the relationships with one another and it gives clever ways of of giving them actions that are specific to only the agents in their Network or other things like that so um yeah that uh concludes thanks nice great work um why or how would somebody use it other than to get

a good handle on the PDP how would you see it being used or adopted for research

cool yeah yeah um so I think uh in scenario like this kind of provides a general agent who can like do things that are defined as exploring or exploiting and so

um what you could do is use it to you know create the the ink landscape laser Freedman model that I I mentioned earlier uh and then and then tweak things from there or you could use this as a more General template like take out the idea that these are attention and outcome modalities and stuff swap them out for you know whatever you want this can have like the template is here for including as many observation modalities in state factors as you want for example uh just change the names and make sure you define the ab CDs you know uh to your liking and so that that's really what I wanted to do just create like here here's here's an example agent because we need to know what the final picture should look like but um you know from there just just tear it apart and like you know to to your hearts content and and make it into to what you want to see these agents can be used to you know um the idea of autonomous decision making that if there are any discrete number of things that you'd want to set up some kind of agent to do and you know what kind of data you want it to read um you know and what what should be the impact of each of those discrete actions

it has like you have this as a kind of
like agent that you can plug into uh
that that sort of design diagram right
so big answer it's pretty abstract sorry
but yeah cool what will be coming up for
the next several
weeks cool yeah um so with the Symposium
I'm looking forward to giving a talk
that's a little bit more uh to the
script uh and less focused on coding and
more on how these kinds of things might
be applied in social science research uh
including looking at uh you know some
other research that has also been done
uh just to try and give a a sense that
is in fact a sort of subfield forming
here and of course we have the the
course on social science done with the
with the Institute itself last year and
um you know different people making
Headway in that area so um looking
forward to that and uh who who knows
what else uh i' very much look forward
to maybe presenting some other research
where I'm using agents like this and
having them interact in kind of
interesting ways with let's say
LMS um and you know these become a kind
of uh fun uh way of trying to imagine
autonomous decision making whenever it
comes to things like prompting so
yeah cool well the video description has
the
links and where things will be
versions and it's a great demo so thank
you any other comments
you um not not currently aside from you
know uh thanks everyone who uh joined

the textbook group and uh you know over
the recent reading uh we're currently
talking through uh other ways that we
might go about the textbook group going
forward but we had a really nice wrapup
conversation yesterday so looking
forward to Future
talks cool okay thank you again Andrew
looking forward to the
next episodes in the
series yeah thanks Daniel thank you
peace take
care for